



Between Extant and Virtual Libraries:

Beckett's Variant Readings of Dante's *Divine Comedy*.

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Beckett Library

Separate module of the *Samuel Beckett Digital Manuscript Project* (BDMP)

- Centre for Manuscript Genetics (Antwerp, BE)
- Beckett International Foundation (Reading, UK)
- Harry Ransom Humanities Research Center (Texas, USA)
- Estate of Samuel Beckett

www.beckettarchive.org



Beckett Library

Exogenetic Dimension

1) EXTANT LIBRARY

- Beckett's Personal library (Paris)
- Beckett International Foundation (Reading)
- Third parties (anywhere)

2) VIRTUAL LIBRARY

- Other books Beckett read (unknown)



Beckett Library

Are personal libraries representative of reading behaviour?

1) Too inclusive?

(we haven't always read all the books we own)

2) Not exhaustive enough?

(we do not always own all the books we've read)



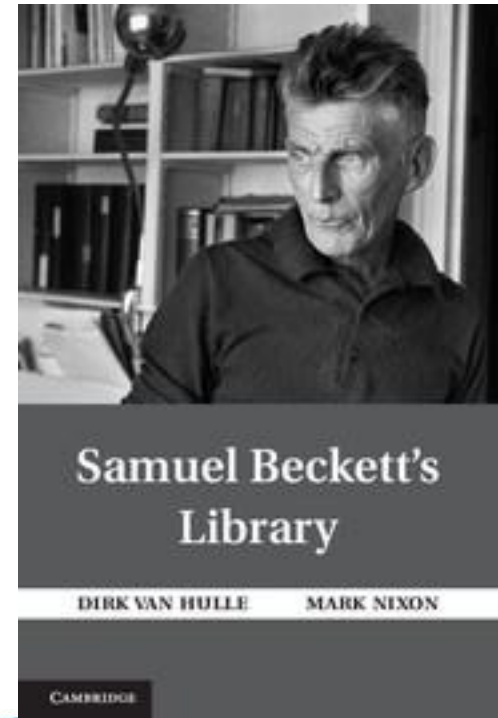
Beckett Library

PROBLEM 1: 'too inclusive'

⇒ Extant Library: focus on reading traces

- pragmatic choice (timeframe)
- methodological choice (substantial evidence)

Van Hulle, Dirk and Mark Nixon (2013) *Samuel Beckett's Library*. Cambridge: Cambridge UP.





Beckett Library

PROBLEM 1: 'too inclusive'

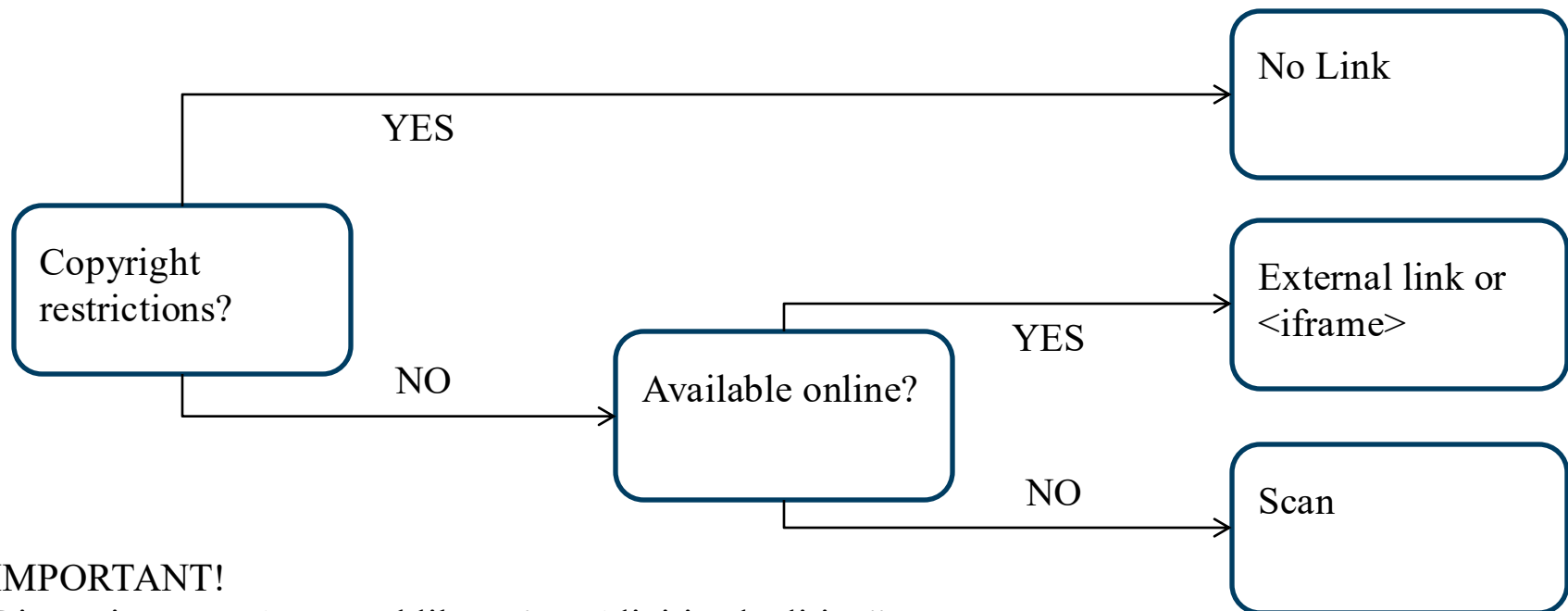
But what about 'non-marginalia' (Gellhaus 2004)?

- LINK TO FULL TEXT:
 - External link
 - Embedded via <iframe>



Beckett Library

Extant Library Links: Workflow



IMPORTANT!

Discursive note: 'personal library' vs. 'digitized edition'



Beckett Library

PROBLEM 2: 'not exhaustive enough'

⇒ Virtual Library: Reference list of books Beckett has read, but which no longer feature in his personal library

- (If possible: link to full text as in Extant Library)

CASE STUDY: Beckett's variant readings of Dante's *Divina Commedia* and translations

Caselli, Daniela (2000) "'The Florentia Edition in the Ignoble Salani Collection": A Textual Comparison,' JoBS 9.2:1-20



Case Study: *La Divina Commedia*

Beckett's treasured copy of Dante's *Divina Commedia*: *SALANI EDITION*

⇒ *But: which one?*

Caselli: Schematic representation of 'Purgatory' copied in *Whoroscope Notebook*

⇒ Dante Alighieri (1921-1922) *La Divina Commedia*, with commentary by Enrico Bianchi. Florence, **Salani**

⇒ Possible to reconstruct Beckett's exact edition by linking Beckett's works to his 'grey canon' (Gontarski 2006)



Case Study: *La Divina Commedia*

Whoroscope Notebook (entries from *Inferno*)

⇒ Dante Alighieri (1922) *La Divina Commedia*, with commentary by **G. A. Scartazzini**, largely revised by **G. Vandelli**. Milan, Hoepli

Dream Notebook (entries from *Purgatorio* footnotes)

⇒ Dante Alighieri (1804) *La Divina Commedia*, illustrated with notes by **Luigi Portirelli**. Milan, Dalla Società Tipografica de' Classici Italiani



Case Study: *La Divina Commedia*

'Papa Isodoro with his primos and secundos and apple-dumpling readings' (*Dream* 51)

⇒ Dante Aligheri (1926) *La Divina Commedia*, with commentary by **Isidoro Del Lungo**. Florence, Le Monnier

Cf. Edward Beckett (qtd. in Caselli 16)

⇒ Dante Aligheri (1897-98) *La Divina Commedia*, edited by **G. L. Passerini**. Florence, Sansoni



Case Study: Translations

Extant editions:

- Dante Alighieri (1869) *The Vision of Hell, Purgatory and Paradise*, translated by **Henry Cary**. London, Bell and Daldy
- Dante Alighieri (1967) *The Divine Comedy*, translated by **Henry Cary**, edited by Edmund Gardner. London, Dent, New York, Dutton



Case Study: Translations

Virtual editions: Cary's or a different translation?

'Sedendo et Quiescendo': pray that he'll let a few **sighs** out of him ere it's too late and speedy promotion from the **Godbirds** (10)

Dream: 'a few **good sighs**' (66)



Case Study: Translations

Salani/ Scartazzini-Vandelli	Beckett	Cary
‘uccel di Dio’	‘Godbirds’	‘bird of God’
‘buon sospiri’	‘good sighs’	‘repentant sighs’

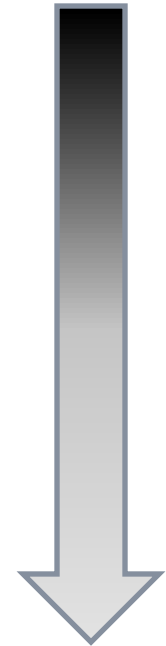
=> inconclusive textual evidence



Grey canon-> greyscale canon?

1. Editions Beckett owned and consulted (**Salani**)
2. Editions Beckett consulted (**Scartazzini-Vandelli** and **Portirelli**)

3. Editions Beckett knew of ('**Papa Isodoro**' and **Passerini**)
4. Books for which the exact editions Beckett read cannot be reconstructed (**translations** of *La Divina Commedia*)





Beckett Library

Editions explicitly linked to the writing process

1.Extant Library: reading traces

2.Virtual Library: editions reconstructed through reading traces in ‘grey canon’ (Salani, Scartazzini-Vandelli, and Portirelli)



References

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